



Support role

A soldier moves cases of ammo in 1967. The Black recruits who arrived through Project 100,000 saw two extremes: dangerous combat missions or menial tasks.

Black power

As a result of President Johnson's so-called Project 100,000, from 1966 to 1969, thousands more Black American soldiers were recruited for the war effort. Forty-one percent of the recruits under this program were Black American, and many were not career soldiers—they hailed from poor urban areas. The majority were assigned to combat roles.

Many of these recruits were more radicalized than those in earlier years. Some called themselves "bloods," and were influenced by the teachings of men such as Malcolm X in the Black Power movement. They objected to poor treatment and demanded the right to express their culture with hairstyles, jewelry, music, and the dap handshake. One Black sailor described watching a man being forcibly shaved and then thrown into a cell for sporting a "short afro," while white men got away with hair "as long as a girl's."

Tensions sometimes erupted into violence, prompting the military to enact reforms in 1969. Military commanders began to name facilities for fallen Black soldiers, include Black entertainers on celebrity tours, play soul music on military-run radio, and make Black grooming products available in the post exchange (PX). Reforms, however, could not eradicate racism in the military. Black American soldiers often came together in solidarity to form groups such as the Unsatisfied Black Soldier to support each other, study their history, and lobby for the small comforts that white men took for granted.